treated with the reverence my generation reserves for such Test greats as Hobbs, Sutcliffe and Bradman.

For me to be linked to them, through the record books, is deeply affecting, and in my more reflective moments a little embarrassing. It's scarcely believable to be spoken of in the same breath as such players. It means I can look back at what I have achieved with a lot of fondness, but I'm obliged to ask myself whether I am worthy of such associations. It risks offending the cricketing gods.

It's slightly easier now that I've retired, and don't have to back it up in international cricket any more, but I'm aware that I might still have to take one for the Oval, just to keep me in my place.